

Moonsea Rising - 20231022

Hail, Hydra!

As the horrible five-headed thing rises from the water and begins to slowly lumber towards the party, Lennox lowers his head and charges. His new sword glimmers darkly in the cave light as he lashes out at the beast, slashing it once. Taevyn dances around the thing, but its mass spans the hallway, he slashes at it, and raises his guard. Harkin fires his bow, striking the monster soundly, as Beitris summons her mystical mace. Lirael attempts to remember anything she can about hydrae, but comes up blank.

Staring at Harken, the hydra launches multiple attacks at Lennox, managing to chomp him heavily, knocking him to the ground. Taevyn grabs Lennox body, and turns to flee, as the creature lashes out at him, felling him instantly. Harken takes one look at the creature, and he and Beitris flee to the underground complex, with Lirael behind them. As it slowly follows them down the corridors, they fire magicks at it. Lirael attempts to charm it. This is unsuccessful, so moving back towards the fire, she calls to the others to lure it into the spores.

Meanwhile, the hydra roars, its wounds healing before Harken and Beitris' eyes. However, it seems unwilling to follow them any further into the keep. Worryingly, it is screaming while staunchly refusing to advance. Harken moves back towards the fire, and when Lirael asks tells her it isn't advancing. She remarks that perhaps they can drive it off, and steps forward, lancing it with a ray of frost. While it hits the creature, the frozen scales quickly mend and look new. Frustrated, it begins to burrow beneath the earth of the stonework. As it seems fixated on the remaining party members, Beitris steps back out and closes the door, obscuring it from their view.

After a few minutes all sounds cease, and they believe the hydra has retreated. Beitris tells Harken that if he can reach Lennox and Taevyn, she should hopefully be able to heal them. He opts to use stealthiness to sneak back to where they last saw the others, and see if they can be retrieved. Sneaking down the corridor invisible, he finds the hydra has brought the lads back to her nest, waiting on her young to hatch to their first meal.

Harken returns and they formulate a plan for Lirael to lead the hydra into the waters in a shark form, with a lighted balloon. When she reaches a point the hydra can see, it immediately moves to follow her. She is much faster than it, and leads it under the overhang. On the other side, the water ends, and the cavern opens up again. The waters lead off to the right, but a set of spike and broken boats block the mouth. She weaves through it, and off down the corridor. As the beast follows her, Beitris sneaks down to the Hydra nest and casts her healing on the two unconscious men, who both wake up groggily. Unfortunately, the healing magicks also cause the hydra eggs to begin hatching. Lirael finds the river forks to the north and south. Further south, an alligator-like river lizard rests. Behind her, the hydra immediately turns towards the sound, and starts moving back the way she came.

Beitris, Lennox, and Taevyn immediately start moving back towards the "safe" stoneworks of the keep. Lirael swims back towards the hydra and bats the light bladder at it, but it is no longer inter-

ested in her. She rapidly swims down the southern branch, hoping to circle back. As she speeds down the waters, the gator follows her, but doesn't manage to catch up to her enough to attack.

Lennox attempts to rush by the hydra, but as he moves past it, it lashes out and fells the giant man once again. Taevyn moves to the nearby crate and attempts to hide from the mother hydra. Harken moves to retrieve Lennox, but the hydra snaps at him and he also drops.

Lirael rolls out of the water away from the gator, and drops her shark form. She runs down the hall back towards the others. Beitris moves forward and heals Harken from a distance. Gesturing frantically, she beckons him to drag Lennox back. He begins dragging him, while Taevyn continues to hide in the corner near the hydra's nest. Lirael comes sprinting up the corridor, and finds Harken, Beitris, and Lennox. She races up, and helps Harken continue dragging Lennox back.

Taevyn tumbles past the hydra, limping up the hallway. Lirael steps up to see the hydra still perilously close to him. Gritting her teeth, she fires a ray of frost at one of the whelps, which screams in pain. The hydra rushes down the corridor, and wraps her body around the whelps, protecting them. Beitris calls to Lirael asking if Taevyn is moving, and the elf says she thinks he might be clear now. She turns to Lennox and heals him, waking the large man up. The party moves painfully back down the hallway, closing the door behind them.

Harken and Beitris are both quite unhappy with Lennox and, to a lesser degree, Taevyn. Lirael is quietly unhappy with the whole ordeal. Lennox also notes that the sword he took from the statue is still lying on the ground in the hydra cave.

The party makes their way back to the goblin's hovel, and bed down for a rest. Lirael describes the remains of the cave system from what she's seen, as they make plans to continue east through the spores. They drive off the gator with spells and arrows, and it retreats north along the "river".

Crossing the bridge, they find the carpet of spores is riddled with mushrooms from small to large size. Beitris thinks she sees one of the mushrooms move, and Lirael hits it with a ray of cold. It shudders, but immediately moves to attack.

Through the Looking Glass

Harken pulls out of a flask of oil and begins preparing an incendiary device. Lirael tells them that, while they're just mushrooms in many respects, it is not a good idea to let them touch you. Taevyn tumbles past the nearest fungus, and pierces it twice, destroying it. Lennox wields his axe, and Beitris casts divine lance, almost destroying the second one. Harken switches out his bomb-making for his rapier, and Lirael sends another ray of frost, at the badly injured mushroom. It whips a sticky tentacle at Lennox, capturing his left hand, and begins squeezing.

Taevyn slashes at it, trying to help free Lennox, who tears his arm free, and strikes with his axe, finally killing it.

As they start down the hallway, one of the largest bushes starts shaking down the middle of the hallway. As Taevyn moves to one side, a rotting tentacle lashes out at his leg. He dances away, stabbing at the tentacle, as several larger fungi rise up from the ground.